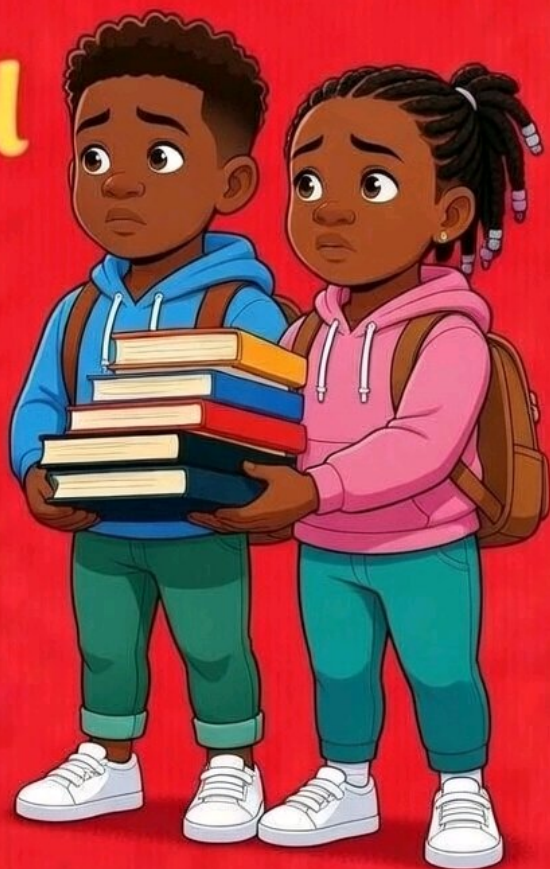


Your Brain Is Lying to You



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Title Page

Your Brain Is Lying to You

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Dedication

To every child who has ever felt scared, unsure, or worried,
and to every grown-up who helps children learn to think bravely.

A Note to Parents and Teachers

Dear Grown-Ups,

This book helps children understand that sometimes their thoughts are not always true. A child may think, “I can’t do this,” or “I am not good enough,” even when that is not real. These thoughts can feel very strong, but they are only thoughts—they are not facts.

In this book, children will learn to notice their thoughts, question them, and choose better, kinder thoughts. Through simple stories, examples, and gentle repetition, they will begin to understand that they can talk back to their thoughts and make brave choices.

You can support this learning by listening, asking simple questions, and reminding children that it is okay to feel unsure—but it is also important to try. Encourage them to share their thoughts and help them find new ways to think when they feel stuck.

Part I: Meet Your Brain

Chapter 1: What Does Your Brain Do?

Your brain is a very special part of your body. It is inside your head, and it works all day and all night, even when you are sleeping. Your brain helps you think, learn, remember things, and make choices. It helps you know when to eat, when to play, when to run, and when to rest. It also helps you feel things like happiness, excitement, worry, or fear. Your brain is like a busy helper that is always working to take care of you and guide you through your day.

Every time you learn something new, your brain is growing. When you learn how to tie your shoes, read a new word, count numbers, or play a game, your brain is practicing and getting stronger. Even when something feels hard, your brain is trying to figure it out. It is like a muscle that gets stronger every time you use it. The more you try, the more your brain learns, and the more confident you become.

Your brain also talks to you. It sends you thoughts all the time. Sometimes your brain says helpful things like, “You can try again,” or “Ask for help,” or “Keep going.” These thoughts help you feel brave and ready to learn. But sometimes your brain can say things that are not so helpful, like “This is too hard,” or “I

can't do this," or "Don't try." These thoughts can make you feel scared or unsure, even when you are actually able to do the task.

It is important to remember that your brain is trying to protect you, but it does not always get it right. Sometimes it thinks something is too hard or too scary when it is not. That is why learning about your brain is so important. When you understand how your brain works, you can start to notice your thoughts and decide which ones to listen to and which ones to change.

Here is a story: Daniel wanted to climb a small hill at the playground. When he looked up, his brain said, "That is too high. You might fall." Daniel felt a little scared and stopped. Then he took a deep breath and looked again. He saw other children climbing safely. He told himself, "I can try slowly." Step by step, he climbed the hill. When he reached the top, he smiled and felt proud. Daniel learned that sometimes his brain says things that are not true, and he can choose to try anyway.

Your brain is powerful, and it helps you every day. But you are even more powerful, because you can learn to understand your thoughts and make brave choices. The more you practice listening to helpful thoughts and changing unhelpful ones, the stronger your mind becomes.

Think about it: What does your brain tell you when you try something new? Does it say, "I can do it," or "I can't do it yet"?

Try this: Next time your brain talks to you, stop and listen. Ask yourself, “Is this thought helping me, or stopping me?” Then choose a thought that helps you try.

Remember: Your brain is strong, but you are the one who can choose how to use it.

Chapter 2: When Your Brain Gets Confused

Your brain is very smart, but sometimes it can get a little confused. It tries to protect you and keep you safe, but it does not always understand everything perfectly. Sometimes your brain sees something new or difficult and quickly says, “This is too hard,” or “This is scary,” even when it is not as big or as scary as it seems. When this happens, your brain is making a mistake. Just like you can make mistakes, your brain can make mistakes too.

Imagine you are about to try something new, like reading a big word, climbing higher on the playground, or answering a question in class. Before you even try, your brain might whisper, “Don’t do it. You might get it wrong.” That thought can make your body feel tight, your heart beat faster, and your hands feel

a little shaky. It might make you want to stop before you even begin. But here is something important to remember: just because your brain says something does not mean it is true. Sometimes your brain is guessing, and sometimes it guesses wrong.

Your brain can also get confused when you make a mistake. You might spill something, get an answer wrong, or forget what to do next. Then your brain might say, “You are not good at this,” or “You should stop trying.” That is your brain being confused. Making a mistake does not mean you cannot do something. It only means you are still learning. Every time you try again, your brain learns something new and becomes less confused.

Here is a story: Amina was learning how to read. She saw a long word in her book and stopped. Her brain quickly said, “That word is too hard. You can’t read it.” Amina felt unsure and wanted to skip the word. But then she paused and thought, “Maybe I can try.” She sounded out each letter slowly. It took time, but she read the whole word. Amina smiled and felt proud. She learned that her brain had been confused, and she was able to help it learn the right answer by trying.

When your brain gets confused, you can help it. You can take a deep breath, slow down, and ask yourself, “Is this really true?” or “Can I try anyway?” You can also ask for help, look again, or try a different way. Each time you do this, you are teaching your

brain to think better and more clearly. Over time, your brain learns to give you more helpful thoughts instead of confusing ones.

Your brain is still learning, just like you. It will not always get everything right, and that is okay. What matters is that you keep trying, keep thinking, and keep learning. The more you practice, the better your brain becomes at telling you the truth.

Think about it: Has your brain ever told you something that made you feel scared or unsure, but you tried anyway? What happened?

Try this: Next time your brain says, “I can’t do it,” stop and say, “Maybe I can try.” Take one small step and see what happens. You might surprise yourself.

Remember: Sometimes your brain gets confused—but you can help it learn the truth by trying, thinking, and not giving up.

Chapter 3: Not All Thoughts Are True

Your brain gives you many thoughts every day. Some thoughts are helpful and true, and some thoughts are not true at all. The tricky part is that all thoughts can feel real, even when they are

not. Your brain might say, “I can’t do this,” or “Everyone is better than me,” or “This is too hard.” When you hear these thoughts, they can feel big and powerful. But here is something very important to remember: not all thoughts are true.

Think about clouds in the sky. Clouds come and go. Some are big, some are small, some are dark, and some are bright. Your thoughts are like clouds. They come into your mind, stay for a little while, and then go away. Just because a cloud is in the sky does not mean it will stay forever. In the same way, just because a thought comes into your mind does not mean you have to believe it or follow it. You can notice it, think about it, and choose what to do next.

Sometimes your brain tells you things to keep you safe, but it can make things seem bigger or scarier than they really are. For example, you might be about to answer a question in class, and your brain says, “Don’t do it. You will get it wrong.” That thought might stop you from trying. But if you think carefully, you may realize, “I am still learning. It is okay to try.” When you choose a better thought, you give yourself a chance to grow and learn.

Here is a story: Kato was learning how to ride a bicycle. The first time he tried, he wobbled and almost fell. His brain quickly said, “You can’t do this. It’s too hard.” Kato felt scared and wanted to stop. But then he looked at his friend riding nearby. He took a deep breath and said, “I can try again.” Slowly, he pushed the pedals and kept going. He wobbled again, but this

time he did not stop. After a few tries, he rode a little farther. Kato learned that his first thought was not true. He could do it—he just needed practice.

When you start to notice your thoughts, you can ask yourself simple questions. You can ask, “Is this thought helping me?” or “Is this really true?” If the thought is not helping you, you can change it. You can say, “I can try,” or “I am learning,” or “I will get better.” These new thoughts help you feel stronger and braver. They help you take small steps forward, even when things feel hard.

Learning that not all thoughts are true gives you a special power. It means you do not have to believe every thought your brain gives you. You can choose the thoughts that help you grow, learn, and feel confident. Over time, your brain will learn from you, and it will start to give you more helpful thoughts.

Think about it: Has your brain ever told you something that made you want to stop trying? What happened when you tried anyway?

Try this: Next time you have a thought like “I can’t do it,” pause and say, “This is just a thought. I can try.” Then take one small step and see what happens.

Remember: Not every thought is true. You can choose thoughts that help you learn, grow, and be brave.

Part II: Understanding Your Thoughts

Chapter 4: Big Thoughts and Small Thoughts

Your brain gives you many thoughts every day, and not all thoughts feel the same. Some thoughts feel very big, and some thoughts feel small and quiet. Big thoughts can feel loud, strong, and sometimes a little scary. They can make your heart beat faster, your body feel tight, or your hands feel shaky. Small thoughts are softer and calmer. They help you feel safe, steady, and ready to try. Learning the difference between big thoughts and small thoughts can help you understand your feelings and make better choices.

Big thoughts often show up when something feels new, tricky, or a little scary. For example, you might be about to try something for the first time, and your brain says, “This is too hard!” or “Don’t do it!” These are big thoughts. They can feel so loud that they try to stop you before you even begin. Big thoughts can make small problems feel very big, like turning a tiny hill into a giant mountain. When this happens, it can feel like you cannot move forward.

Small thoughts are different. Small thoughts are calm, gentle, and helpful. They might say, “You can try,” or “Take it step by step,” or “It’s okay to learn.” Small thoughts help you feel brave

and steady, even if you are a little nervous. They do not make the problem disappear, but they help you see it clearly and handle it one step at a time. Small thoughts are like a quiet friend standing next to you, reminding you that you can do your best.

Here is a story: Lila wanted to jump over a small puddle. When she looked at it, her brain gave her a big thought: “You will fall! It’s too big!” Lila stepped back and felt unsure. Then she paused and took a deep breath. She looked again and noticed the puddle was not so big after all. She told herself a small thought: “I can try. I can jump.” She bent her knees, jumped, and landed safely on the other side. Lila smiled. She learned that her big thought made the puddle seem bigger than it really was, but her small thought helped her see the truth and try.

When big thoughts come, you do not have to push them away or feel bad about them. Instead, you can notice them and say, “That is a big thought.” Then you can look for a small, helpful thought to guide you. You can say, “I can try,” or “I can go slowly,” or “I can ask for help.” These small thoughts help your body relax and your mind focus. The more you practice choosing small thoughts, the easier it becomes.

Your brain will always have both big thoughts and small thoughts. That is normal. But you have a special power—you can choose which thoughts to follow. When you choose small, helpful thoughts, you give yourself a chance to learn, grow, and

feel proud of trying.

Think about it: Can you remember a time when a big thought made something feel scary or hard? What small thought could you use instead?

Try this: Next time you feel a big thought, stop and say, “That is a big thought.” Then choose a small thought like, “I can try.” Take one step and see how you feel.

Remember: Big thoughts can feel loud, but small thoughts help you move forward, step by step.

Chapter 5: Talking Back to Your Thoughts

Your brain talks to you every day, but here is something very special—you can talk back to your brain. When your brain gives you a thought that feels scary, untrue, or unhelpful, you do not have to just listen and believe it. You can stop, think, and answer it with a better thought. This is called talking back to your thoughts, and it is a powerful way to help yourself feel brave, calm, and ready to try.

Sometimes your brain might say, “I can’t do this,” or “I will get it wrong,” or “This is too hard.” These thoughts can make you feel

like stopping before you even begin. But when you talk back, you can gently say, “I can try,” or “I am still learning,” or “It’s okay to make mistakes.” These new thoughts help your body relax and give you the courage to take the next step. Talking back does not mean being angry at your brain—it means helping your brain learn the truth.

Here is a story: Daniel was asked to read a sentence in class. When he looked at the words, his brain quickly said, “Don’t try. You will mess up.” Daniel felt nervous and wanted to stay quiet. Then he remembered he could talk back to his thoughts. He took a deep breath and said quietly to himself, “I can try. It’s okay if I make a mistake.” He began to read. He made a small mistake, but he kept going. When he finished, he felt proud. Daniel learned that when he talked back to his thoughts, he could do more than he first believed.

Talking back to your thoughts can be simple. You can ask yourself, “Is this thought helping me?” If the answer is no, you can choose a better one. For example, if your brain says, “I am not good at this,” you can say, “I am learning.” If it says, “I will fail,” you can say, “I can try my best.” These small changes in your thoughts can make a big difference in how you feel and what you do next.

The more you practice talking back, the easier it becomes. At first, it might feel a little strange, but that is okay. Your brain is learning from you. Each time you choose a helpful thought, you

are teaching your brain to think in a kinder and stronger way. Over time, your brain will start to give you more helpful thoughts on its own.

Think about it: Has your brain ever told you something that made you want to stop? What could you say back to that thought?

Try this: Next time your brain says, “I can’t do it,” pause and say, “I can try.” Then take one small step. Notice how you feel when you choose a new thought.

Remember: You can talk back to your thoughts. You can choose words that help you be brave, keep trying, and grow stronger every day.

Chapter 6: Choosing Better Thoughts

Now that you know you can talk back to your thoughts, there is something even more powerful you can do—you can choose better thoughts. This means when your brain gives you a thought that is not helpful, you can replace it with a thought that helps you feel calm, brave, and ready to try. Choosing better thoughts is like picking the right tool for a job. Some thoughts make things harder, but better thoughts help you move forward,

step by step.

Sometimes your brain may say, “I can’t do this,” and that thought can make you feel stuck. But you can stop and choose a better thought, like, “I can try,” or “I can learn.” These better thoughts do not need to be perfect—they just need to help you take the next step. When you choose a better thought, your body begins to relax, your mind feels clearer, and you feel more ready to try again.

Here is a story: Aisha was trying to draw a picture of a house. The lines did not look the way she wanted, and her brain said, “This is not good. You can’t draw.” Aisha felt like giving up. Then she remembered she could choose a better thought. She took a deep breath and said, “I am still learning. I can try again.” She picked up her pencil and started again, slowly and carefully. This time, her drawing looked better. Aisha smiled because she did not give up. She chose a better thought, and it helped her keep going.

Choosing better thoughts also helps when you feel scared or unsure. If your brain says, “This is too scary,” you can say, “I can go slowly,” or “I can ask for help.” These thoughts remind you that you are not alone and that you can take small steps. You do not have to do everything at once. Better thoughts help you focus on what you can do right now, instead of what feels too big.

It is important to remember that choosing better thoughts takes practice. Sometimes the first thought that comes into your mind will not be helpful. That is okay. You can pause, think, and gently choose a new thought. Each time you do this, you are training your brain to think in a stronger and kinder way. Over time, your brain will learn from you and begin to give you better thoughts more often.

Think about it: What is one thought your brain says that makes things feel hard? What better thought could you choose instead?

Try this: Next time you feel stuck or scared, stop and pick a better thought. Say it quietly to yourself, like “I can try,” or “I am learning.” Then take one small step forward.

Remember: You can choose your thoughts. Better thoughts help you feel brave, keep trying, and grow stronger every day.

Part III: Using Your Brain Power

Chapter 7: Trying Even When It Feels Hard

Sometimes things feel hard. You might be learning something new, trying to solve a problem, or doing something you have never done before. In those moments, your brain might say, “Stop,” or “This is too hard,” or “You can’t do this.” When that happens, you may feel like giving up. Your body might feel tired, your mind might feel stuck, and you might want to walk away. But this is exactly the moment when your brain power is most important.

Trying when something feels hard is a very special kind of bravery. It does not mean the task becomes easy right away. It means you keep going, even if you feel unsure. You take one small step, then another, and then another. Each step may feel tiny, but together they help you move forward. When you keep trying, your brain is learning, growing, and becoming stronger, even if you do not see it right away.

Here is a story: Musa was learning how to write his letters. Some letters were easy, but others were tricky. One day, he tried to write a letter, and it did not look right. His brain said, “This is too hard. Stop.” Musa felt frustrated and put his pencil down. Then he remembered that he could choose a better

thought. He took a deep breath and said, “I can try again.” He picked up his pencil and slowly traced the letter. It was not perfect, but it was better. He tried again, and again, and each time he improved a little. By the end, Musa smiled because he had not given up.

Trying when it feels hard also means being patient with yourself. You do not have to get everything right the first time. Learning takes time. Mistakes will happen, and that is okay. Each mistake is teaching you something new. When you keep trying, you are telling yourself, “I am learning,” and that is much more powerful than saying, “I can’t do it.”

Sometimes, trying also means asking for help. You can ask a teacher, a parent, or a friend to guide you. Asking for help is not a sign of weakness—it is a sign of strength. It means you care about learning and growing. With help, practice, and patience, things that once felt hard can become easier over time.

Think about it: Can you remember something that felt hard at first, but got easier when you kept trying? How did it feel when you didn’t give up?

Try this: Next time something feels hard, stop and say, “I can try.” Then take one small step. If it is still hard, take another step. Keep going, little by little.

Remember: Hard things help your brain grow. Every time you

try, even when it feels difficult, you are becoming stronger, smarter, and braver.

Chapter 8: Making Mistakes and Learning Anyway

Sometimes, when you try something new or difficult, you will make a mistake. That is normal. It happens to everyone—children, teachers, parents, and even people who are very good at what they do. But when you make a mistake, your brain might quickly say, “Oh no! You got it wrong,” or “You should stop.” These thoughts can make you feel sad, frustrated, or even a little embarrassed. You might want to hide your mistake or give up. But here is something very important: making mistakes is part of learning, and you can keep learning anyway.

When you make a mistake, it does not mean you cannot do something. It only means you are still learning how to do it. Every mistake is like a small lesson. It shows you what to try next or what to do differently. If you stop because of a mistake, you miss the chance to learn. But if you keep going, even after a mistake, your brain grows stronger and understands more. Learning happens when you try, make mistakes, and try again.

Here is a story: Neema was learning how to count numbers.

One day, her teacher asked her to count out loud. Neema started well, but then she skipped a number. Some children laughed, and Neema felt embarrassed. Her brain said, “Stop. You can’t do this.” Neema looked down and felt like giving up. Then she remembered that mistakes are part of learning. She took a deep breath and said, “I can try again.” This time, she counted slowly and carefully. She made it all the way through. Neema felt proud, not because she was perfect, but because she did not give up.

Making mistakes and learning anyway also means being kind to yourself. Instead of saying, “I am not good,” you can say, “I am learning.” Instead of thinking, “I failed,” you can think, “I will try again.” These small changes in your thoughts help you feel stronger and more confident. They help you see mistakes as steps forward, not as something to fear.

Sometimes, learning from mistakes takes time. You may need to try again many times before something feels easy. That is okay. Each try is helping your brain understand more. Each mistake is helping you grow. Over time, things that once felt hard begin to feel easier, and you begin to feel proud of how far you have come.

Think about it: Can you remember a mistake that helped you learn something new? What happened when you tried again?

Try this: Next time you make a mistake, pause and say, “It’s

okay. I am learning.” Then try again, slowly and carefully. Notice how you feel when you keep going.

Remember: Mistakes are not the end. They are part of learning. When you keep trying, you grow stronger, smarter, and more confident every day.

Part IV: Taking Charge of Your Brain

Chapter 9: You Are in Charge of Your Thoughts

Your brain is very busy. It gives you hundreds of thoughts every day. Some thoughts make you feel strong, brave, and happy. Other thoughts can make you feel small, worried, or unsure. The amazing thing is that you are the boss of your thoughts. You can choose which thoughts to listen to and which thoughts to change. You can pick thoughts that help you grow, learn, and try new things, even when it feels tricky or scary.

Being in charge of your thoughts does not mean your brain will stop giving you big, scary, or unhelpful ideas. Those thoughts will still come sometimes, and that is okay. Everyone has them. The important part is that you can notice them, pause, and then choose a better thought. Choosing better thoughts is like holding a magic shield in your hand. It does not make the problem disappear, but it helps you feel safe, strong, and ready to move forward.

Here is a story: Juma was learning to tie his shoelaces. Every time he tried, his laces got tangled. His brain said, "You can't do this. You will never get it." Juma felt frustrated and wanted to give up. Then he remembered he was in charge of his thoughts. He took a deep breath and said, "I can try. I am learning." He tried again, slowly and carefully, and this time he made progress. After a few tries, Juma tied one shoelace all by himself! His brain had given him tricky thoughts, but he chose better ones, and he succeeded.

When you are in charge of your thoughts, you also learn to be patient with yourself. Some days will feel harder than others. Some mistakes will happen, and that is okay. Being patient and kind to yourself is part of taking charge. You can say, "It's okay. I am learning," or "I will try again." These words are powerful because they remind you that you are capable, no matter what your first thought says.

You are in charge of your thoughts when you notice them, choose helpful ones, and

act on them. You can decide to take a deep breath, try again, ask for help, or say, “I can do this.” Every time you make that choice, your brain grows stronger. Your courage grows bigger. Your mistakes start to feel smaller, and your confidence grows. You are learning the most important lesson of all: you have the power to guide your mind and grow every day.

Think about it: Which thoughts do you hear most often? Which thoughts help you, and which thoughts do you want to change?

Try this: Today, notice one thought that makes something feel hard. Pause and choose a better thought, like “I can try” or “I am learning.” Then take one step, no matter how small, and see what happens.

Remember: You are the boss of your thoughts. The thoughts you choose help you learn, grow, and become stronger every single day.

Back Matter: Your Brain Is Lying to You

Brain Activity Pages

1. Draw a Tricky Thought

Think of a time when your brain told you something that wasn't completely true. Maybe it said, "I can't do this," or "This is scary," even when it wasn't really dangerous. On this page, draw what that thought looked like in your head. Then draw yourself choosing a better thought, like "I can try," or "It's okay, I am learning." Use bright colors, shapes, and even faces. This will help you see that you have power over your thoughts and can change them.

2. Brain Journal

Write or tell a story about a tricky thought you had today. What did your brain say first? How did it make you feel? What did you do instead? If writing is hard, you can draw pictures first and then ask a grown-up to help you add words. Keeping a journal of your thoughts helps you notice patterns, recognize when your brain is lying, and see how strong and brave you are.

3. Thought Challenge

Try one small action every day to practice noticing and changing tricky thoughts. Some ideas are:

Say "I can try" when something feels hard.

Take a deep breath before deciding what to do.

Tell yourself a kind thought, like “I am learning” or “I can do this.”

Ask for help when you feel stuck.

Each time you complete a challenge, notice how your brain feels and circle the day on a chart. Over time, you will see that you have more control and confidence.

Reflection Prompts

Can you remember a time your brain told you something that wasn't true? What happened when you tried anyway?

Which thoughts make you feel brave, happy, or strong?

Which thoughts make you feel worried, small, or stuck?

Who can help you when tricky thoughts feel too big?

Take a few moments to think, draw, or talk to a grown-up about

your answers. Reflection helps your brain grow smarter, stronger, and braver.

Brain Growth Promise

Repeat this promise every morning, or whenever your brain tries to trick you:

“My brain gives me thoughts,
But I am the boss of them.
I can choose better thoughts,
I can try, I can learn, and I can grow.
Every day, my brain gets stronger, and so do I.”

You can say it quietly in your mind, out loud, or with a friend or family member. Each time you say it, you practice guiding your thoughts and growing your confidence.

For Grown-Ups: Helping Children Guide Their Brains

1. Notice and name thoughts: Help children recognize when a

thought is unhelpful or not true. Say, “Your brain is giving you a tricky thought. What could we think instead?”

2. Model thoughtful thinking: Share your own tricky thoughts and how you change them. Children learn by seeing adults handle their minds calmly.

3. Encourage reflection: Ask questions like, “What did your brain tell you?” and “Which thought can help you feel brave?”

4. Praise effort over results: Celebrate children noticing tricky thoughts and choosing helpful ones, even if the outcome isn’t perfect.

5. Practice regularly: Offer small daily exercises to guide thoughts, like deep breathing, saying a kind thought, or trying something new.

By using these strategies, adults help children grow self-awareness, confidence, and emotional strength, learning that their brains can give tricky thoughts, but they are always in charge of how they respond.